

Don't be too hope-fool

As we enter the final week of March, April Fools' shenanigans increase in rate, peaking on 1st of April, of course. Over the years, technology companies big and small have joined in on the fun, with untrue announcements and hoax-filled product launches to playfully prank unsuspecting users and visitors.

I remember quite a few of Google's April Fools' pranks. Long before Elon Musk's Neuralink, there was Google MentalPlex from circa 2000, a brain-computer interface that promised to enhance your mood by just sensing your brainwaves. Gmail Paper from April 2007 was another famous Google prank, as the cheeky service claimed to let you print your Gmail emails on eco-friendly paper in bulk quantities and have them shipped to you anywhere in the world. My favourite Google prank of all time was Google TiSP from 2005. It was a fictional free internet service that promised 8 Mbps of high-speed internet access delivered through your toilet, with fibre-optic cables pulled through sewage lines no less! I still remember reading it on April 1, almost twenty years ago, browsing the web over my measly 256 Kbps connection. In all honesty, I fell for it, thanks to India's pathetic broadband network at the time and what appeared to be Google's ingenious solution to a very real problem, so convincing was the prank!

However, not all pranks and schemes are crafted with the spirit of harmless fun in mind. In recent years, the line between jest and deception has blurred, with scammers leveraging the frivolity of April Fools' Day to cause some serious damage. Two notable recent instances bring this unsettling trend to light, serving as a stern reminder that being a hopeful fool in the digital age can be far more risky than it appears.

Last year, the "ScamAdviser Coin" project, a purported awareness campaign by the Global Anti Scam Alliance and ScamAdviser, masqueraded as an investment opportunity (that was going to launch on April 1, 2023) offering unbelievable returns. The creation of a fake company and the promotion of this hoax investment platform showcased the disturbing ease with which digital platforms could be manipulated to defraud eager investors trying to earn a quick buck. As many as 144 users were ready



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to invest a total of US \$11,010, as this campaign highlighted not just how easily the public could be fooled but also the critical need for more rigorous due diligence and policy reforms to safeguard against such digital deceptions from spreading online.

Going beyond exploiting April Fools', real scammers have honed their craft with increasingly sophisticated cons that fly below the radar of trending occasions. From masquerading as venture capitalists to hijack funds, exploiting Google Workspace features for phishing scams, and who can forget all the Elon Musk crypto scams? From doctored YouTube videos to fake social media accounts impersonating or featuring Elon Musk (possibly deep fakes) discussing crypto giveaways to spam emails with enticing subject lines like "Elon Musk Crypto Giveaway!" landing in your inbox, scammers were especially sneaky in trying to steal your crypto holdings in 2023. These incidents underscore the paramount importance of constant vigilance and thorough research before leaping at seemingly lucrative financial opportunities.

As amusing as some April Fools' Day pranks can be, the emergence of these scams serves as a stark reminder of the darker possibilities that lie beneath surface-level jest. At a time when digital spaces are battlegrounds for both innovation and exploitation, the need for constantly staying alert and aware of inbound cybersecurity threats has never been more critical. As we navigate the complexities of the internet, let us do so with a healthy dose of scepticism, particularly towards offers that seem too good to be true. After all, in the vast expanse of the digital world, not every April Fool's joke is designed to end with a laugh. Instead, some seek to exploit the hopeful fool in us all, turning naive gullibility into a costly mistake.

This April, as we revel in the humour and creativity that tech companies bring to the table, let's not forget to guard ourselves against the cunning schemes deployed by scammers hidden in plain sight. Stay safe, stay sceptical, and let's ensure that the only things we're losing to April Fools' are our momentary disbeliefs and a few hearty laughs, not our hard-earned money or personal data. **d**



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